



Academic Libraries' Outreach Efforts: Identifying Themes in the Literature

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Outreach programs remain essential in fostering the use of library collections and services. A review of one hundred seventy-four papers on academic library outreach from 2008 to January 2019 highlighted the popularity of these programs during this period as well as the identification of five themes. These themes point to the importance of library outreach to targeted groups, the popularity of specialized library outreach programs, the need for collaboration in fostering outreach efforts, the benefits of managing these programs and the use of social media for library outreach. Foremost, these materials highlight opportunities and challenges for librarians in providing library outreach in academic institutions.

KEYWORDS diversity, collaboration, events, management, social media

INTRODUCTION

Outreach programs remain essential in fostering the use of library collections and services. In Boyer (1987), Boyer alluded to the importance of library outreach in *College: The undergraduate experience in America*.

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He encouraged colleges to “open their own libraries to teachers and selected high school students” (p. 164). He urged librarians to provide bibliographic instruction to students as well as to schedule activities that “feature books and reading” (p. 165). Outreach efforts provide an opportunity to include and educate library users, campus as well as community residents, on various subjects as well as demonstrate the library’s value to the academy (Vann, 2013). Likewise, in the digital era librarians compete with a multitude of online sources for use of the libraries’ materials. Vilelle and Barber (2013) stated the library’s “relationship with students is not guaranteed, and neither are our ties to the faculty” (p. 83). Johnson, McCord, and Walter (2003) maintained new models of outreach capitalized on librarians’ knowledge as well as their information skills. According to Morris (2007) the new model for academic library outreach must honor the mission of the institution and its people. Andrews (2012) suggested outreach efforts include web 2.0 and social networking tools, communication and digital media devices, attention to collaboration, participation in freshmen orientations seminars, and library instruction relevant to the real world. Freeman and Freeman (2016) advised readers to utilize creative strategies, remain flexible and especially to think outside the box when devising outreach programs. The outreach programs identified in the library literature from 2008 to January 2019 illustrate librarians’ efforts to attract and support diverse populations through various programs.

Background

The library profession lacks a definitive definition of outreach. Courtney (2009) defined outreach as “reaching out to those outside the library” but she noted there was little consensus on to whom that included (p. 1). Research pointed to a variety of outreach initiatives described in the literature and these centered on instruction, cooperation, and special programming. Authors traced academic librarians’ instructional efforts to the late 1800s with the availabilities of an optional credit course focused on bibliography, books, printing and library use (Glynn, 1991). According to the Salony (1995), interest in librarians’ instructional initiatives in higher education varied until the 1960s with the creation of the American Library Association’s (ALA) Committee on Instruction in Library Use. There was also early evidence of library outreach linked to cooperation or community based and especially research sharing. In 1958, *Library Trends* centered an issue on library cooperation and it included articles from public as well as academic libraries in the United States and abroad. Eight years later a survey of the ACRL College Libraries revealed nearly all of its members provided some form of outreach services to the community (Josey, 1966). More recently librarians adopted special programming efforts to attract users, especially diverse and underserved populations. Some of the

programming initiatives noted by authors included the library open house, exhibits, book talks, instructional workshops, and multi-media kiosks (Fabian et al., 2003; Odom & Strout-Dapaz, 2000). Case studies documented in *Outreach services in academic and special libraries* seemingly identified these three categories of outreach including: instruction, cooperation or community based and special programming (Kelsey & Kelsey, 2003). Consequently, we adopt these components of library outreach in crafting our definition for this review.

LITERATURE REVIEW METHOD

The literature review tracked academic libraries' outreach efforts through an examination of peer reviewed papers on the topic from 2008 to January 2019. The keywords utilized in the search included the following: outreach, library, university, college, higher education and academic in the subject, title or abstract fields. Moreover, the authors selected databases that contained library literature such as Emerald, Academic Search Premier, Science Direct, Library and Information Science Abstracts, ERIC, and Education Research Complete. The authors' search strategy included truncating terms, reviewing the reference list of relevant papers, limiting results to items published in English.

Limitations

The search was limited to the preceding decade because the authors sought articles that reflected the current diversity in academic institutions particularly in race, religion, ethnicity, and sexual orientation among students, faculty, and staff. The authors aimed to capitalize on the popularity of social media as a form of outreach and availabilities of other technologies. However, the limitation of the review to the last ten years and academic libraries may have obscured papers that contained additional material relevant to the topic. Still, incorporating this research would have greatly expanded the number of hits resulting in an unwieldy result set.

The authors sought to synthesize as well as summarize the literature through qualitative and quantitative strategies (McKibbin, 2006). Qualitative measures were utilized to assign codes for the material adopting Glaser and Strauss' (1967) constant comparative method that led to the authors' identification of five themes and various subthemes. They employed quantitative measures to identify the numbers of papers within the five themes (Vassilakaki, 2014).

Research Analysis & Findings

The authors reviewed papers ($N=174$) that focused on library outreach in academic institutions. These papers included a variety of materials such as book chapters, journal articles, and opinion pieces. The literature illustrated library outreach activities through the lens of five major themes and these are listed in Table 1. These themes point to the importance of the following including: library outreach to targeted groups, specialized library outreach programs, collaboration in fostering outreach efforts, the management of these programs and the use of social media for library outreach. Foremost, these materials highlight opportunities and challenges for librarians in providing library outreach in academic institutions. The authors present a discussion of each theme in the following section.

Targeted Groups

The largest group of papers ($N=67$) focused on academic librarians' outreach to targeted groups. Table 2 lists the subthemes identified in this body of the literature. The wide range of target audiences illustrated librarians' attempt to provide outreach to campus as well as community residents. These efforts also underscore the importance of developing outreach programs that reflect the needs of different user groups.

TABLE 1 Distribution of Themes and Papers in the Literature.

Themes	Number of Papers
Library outreach to targeted groups	67
Library outreach programs	47
Collaboration in fostering library outreach	25
Management of library outreach efforts	19
Use of social media for library outreach	16

TABLE 2 Distribution of Subthemes and Number of References in the Targeted Groups Papers.

Subthemes of Targeted Groups	Number of Papers
Outreach to community organizations and area residents	19
Outreach by class standing	11
Outreach to international students	9
Outreach to veterans, athletes, college staff, as well as adult, transfer, and distance education students	9
Outreach to diverse bodies	8
Outreach to faculty	6
Outreach by academic major	5

Community

Papers ($N=19$) describing campus and community organizations and area residents formed the largest library outreach programs described in this component of the literature. Several programs centered on librarians' outreach to middle and high school students and their librarians. These initiatives included STEM workshops, information literacy instruction, technology training, library orientations, interlibrary loan support, partnerships with high school librarians, and scavenger hunts (Adkins, Anderson, & Skekloff, 2014; Angell & Tewell, 2013; Burhanna, Gedeon, Jensen, & Schloman, 2009; Cahoy & Moyo, 2009; Coleman & McCraw, 2009; Flash, Allen, Mack & Clement, 2017; Garcia, 2009; Gee, 2011; Gresham & Van Tassel, 2000; Hadebe, Kear, & Smith, 2009; Thorne-Ortiz, 2013). Other targeted groups included college alumni and donors, seniors, and community businesses. Outreach programs for these individuals highlighted the importance of the following including: library orientations, Libguides, staff training, collection building, computer access, library workshops, and partnerships with various entities (Dole & Hill, 2011; Griffis, 2015; Konzak & Teague, 2009; Strong, Guillot, & Badeau, 2012). Library exhibits remained a popular form of outreach, but unique events such as film series and the establishment of a Friends of the Library group attracted users as well (Crawford, 2012; Holliday & Lee, 2014; Leong, 2013; Liauw, 2014).

Class Standing

There was also a large number of papers ($N=11$) outlining programs that described outreach efforts based on students' class standing. Many of the articles focused on outreach initiatives directed at graduates and post-graduate students (Gurman & Brunner, 2015; Kang, 2016). MacKenzie (2014) pointed to the importance of information literacy instruction, research assistance, and data management to these students. Research supported the use of roaming library support for librarians' outreach to doctoral and post-doctoral students as well as digital and face-to-face orientations (Foster, 2009; Tomaszewski, 2012). Articles highlighted the importance of reaching out to undergraduates too, especially first year students through orientation week programs, introductory courses, learning communities, student led programs, citation skill assistance, online instruction, open houses, a Senior Summit, and other library events. (Collins & Dodsworth, 2011; Currie, 2009; Kuglitsch & Burge, 2016; Hare & Evanson, 2018). Outreach to students living on campus was fostered by partnerships with student support groups and centered on live-in librarians that hosted book clubs, offered onsite research support, and citation skill assistance (Nicholas et al., 2015; Strothmann & Antell, 2010).

International Students

A significant number ($N=9$) of papers described librarians' outreach efforts to international and generation 1.5 students. Articles advised librarians to participate in their institutions' international week, assess users' needs, note the differences among foreign students, recognize the role of the library as a place to these students, and appreciate the value of instruction to this group (Asher, 2011; Mundava & Gray, 2008; Puente, Gray, & Agnew, 2009; Ye, 2009). The literature supported the following including: the availability of orientations for international students, the creation of webpages geared for international students, the development of research skills workshops, the delivery of training in students' native language, the creation of audio tours, the provision of film series and post movie discussion, the conduction of instructional assessments, and the establishment of a multicultural librarian position (Bridges, 2014; Ganster, 2011; Kinder & Montgomery, 2015; Langer & Kubo, 2015; Rosenzweig & Meade, 2017).

Others Groups

Some papers ($N=9$) documented programs that were directed at other users such as veterans, athletes, college staff, as well as adult, transfer, and distance education students. Librarians outreach to veterans and Army Reserve Officers' Training Corps students encompassed collaborations with faculty, library instruction and assessment, the creation of specialized collections, targeted websites, communicating through email, and providing support in campus areas popular among these individuals (Atwood et al., 2016; Mills, Paladino, & Klentzin, 2015; Rod-Welch, Weeg, & Keith, 2017). On the other hand, outreach to student athletes included library support at the athletic center, the appointment of a library liaison, and an information literacy course for incoming athletics (Caniano, 2015). However, an outreach initiative to child care facility staff centered on a curriculum collection workshop (Edwards & Thornton, 2013). Older, transfer, and distance education students represented other special users that librarians provided targeted outreach to and some efforts included the following: collaboration with various campus groups, a liaison librarian, special events, library tours, flexible office hours for research support, the use of webpages with librarian links, subject Libguides and orientation sessions (Cannady, King, & Blendinger, 2012; Detar, 2018; Ismail, 2011; Roberts, Welsh, & Dudek, 2019).

Diverse Student Bodies

Librarians' outreach efforts to diverse student bodies described in the papers, ($N=8$), encompassed underrepresented academic groups by race,

gender, and sexual orientation, as well as at risk students and individuals with physical disabilities and those from lower socio-economic classes. Authors advocated utilizing published reports to identify these students, interviewing faculty for suggestions on how to support them, and utilizing the information to develop appropriate outreach initiatives (Reading, 2016; Rutledge & LeMire, 2016). Articles suggested outreach to diverse student groups can be furthered by the provision of offsite library support, the promotion of the library as a safe place for all individuals, the creation of a diversity librarian position, the incorporation of information literacy skills instruction in classwork, the inclusion of underrepresented groups in exhibits, the availability of staff diversity training, the use of various technologies, the provision of online and face-to face instruction, and collaborative efforts with various campus entities (Aguilar & Keating, 2009; Evans, Herold, & Sharrow, 2018; Everett, 2018; Gray, 2010; Meyers-Martin & Lampert, 2013). Research also supported the use of special collections and archives for outreach to cultural groups (Bishop, Pringle & Tsosie, 2017).

Faculty

Faculty comprised another targeted group for library outreach noted in the papers ($N=6$). Outreach efforts to these individuals included the creation of library webpages for faculty, personalized communication and the delivery of information on the following including: scholarly communication, open access, copyright, library resources, digital trends, social media apps, and author rights (Essinger & Ke, 2013; Gardner, Juricek, & Xu, 2008; Virtue & Esparza, 2013; Wright, 2013). Many of the outreach initiatives occurred through department liaisons. Research suggested librarians sought to introduce new faculty and support existing staff through the use of social events and the educational opportunities for liaisons (Corbin, 2008; Malenfant, 2010).

Academic Majors

Librarians also developed outreach programs to students based on their academic majors especially for art, STEM, engineering, and business students and these papers ($N=5$) appeared in the literature too. These papers highlighted the importance of hosting library orientations, creating research guides, collaborating with faculty, utilizing alternative communication tools, providing library support hours in students' space, such as art students, and other strategies designed to reach out to students (Arrieta & Kern, 2015; Leousis, 2013; Mallon, 2014; Torrence, 2015). The research highlighted the important of librarian liaison roles, instruction, orientation,

TABLE 3 Distribution of Subthemes and Number of References in the Descriptions of Library Outreach Programs Papers.

Subthemes of Library Programs	Number of Papers
Instruction and information	10
Roaming services	9
Orientations and other activities	9
Gaming	6
Exhibits	6
Makerspaces	4
Collections	3

virtual services, and staff involvement in professional development to engineering, math and physical sciences students (Wilson, 2013).

Specialized Programs

The review contained papers ($N=47$) that centered on descriptions of library outreach programs. These included a range of events, programs, and activities designed to inform students about the library, provide instruction, and offer educational and entertaining activities. The subthemes are listed in Table 3.

Instruction and Information

Papers ($N=10$) noted librarians considered instructional and other educational efforts as a form of outreach. Some of these educational events included information literacy instruction to students as well as the provision of health, legal, and political information to community residents (Johnson, 2009; Okoye, Imo, & Igvo, 2010; Raimondo, Tatro, & Mayo, 2009; Rowland, 2014; Salinero & Beardsley, 2009; Saylor, Schnitzer, Allee, & Blumenthal, 2011; Seeger, 2009). Likewise, librarians promoted partnerships with faculty for course integrated information literacy instruction (Gallaway, Kelly, Sullivan, & Willey, 2016). Librarians utilized various avenues and technologies to promote library resources services and activities including a mobile phone alert system at the University of North Carolina at Charlotte and a workshop series at the University of Notre Dame Libraries (Bergstrom & Papson, 2016; Bess, Wu, & Price, 2015).

Roaming Services

Papers ($N=9$) linked librarians' efforts to provide reference services outside of the library as outreach initiatives. Many of these programs focused on the use of iPads or tablets that enabled librarians to deliver reference services to popular student areas on campus or during school events

(Gadsby & Qian, 2012; Sharman & Walsh, 2012). In other instances librarians were located within departments, dormitories or provided virtual reference services and mobile book carts (Aguilar, Keating, Schadl, & Van Reenen, 2011; Benne, Jackson, Kostelecky, & Quinn, 2019; Lai, 2015; Nicholas et al., 2015; Rudin, 2008; Tugwell & Tyrell, 2015). Authors pointed to the importance of conducting assessments to identify optimal locations and to evaluate library usage of the service (Helms, Oliveira, Maticio, & Kimakwa, 2016).

Orientations and Other Activities

Papers ($N=9$) documented a variety of outreach activities performed by academic librarians. Librarians viewed orientations as outreach and they designed them to be educational as well as entertaining (Evans, 2016; Miller & Cooper, 2014; Tiffen & England, 2011). Library open houses remained especially popular and they often coincided with opening weekend and included representatives from other campus groups and offered activities and giveaways to students (Anderson, 2010). Other events described in the literature were designed to bring students into the library such as a Book Culture Club at Hong Kong Baptist University Library and the University of Southern Indiana's Rice Library's Banned Books Week, Blind Date With a Book, Black History Month at the University of Mississippi Libraries, as well as Popcorn Day at the University of Central Florida Harriet Ginsburg Health Sciences Library (Chan, 2015; Clark, Hostetler, & Loehrlein, 2014; Rogers & Gibson, 2018; Williams & Gillum, 2018). Similarly, a survey of 279 librarians' exam week outreach efforts identified the popularity of extended hours, therapy animals, games and arts and crafts to support students during this period (Meyers-Martin & Borchard, 2015).

Gaming

Gaming represented another form of library outreach described in the papers ($N=6$). The majority of these events centered on librarians' use of video based games to promote the library space and its resources (Courtier & DeLooper, 2017). Authors emphasized the popularity of these events, the low cost of the initiatives, the importance of planning, the value of assessment, and the advantages of marketing (Bishoff, Farrell, & Neeser, 2015; Vanden Elzen & Roush, 2013). The literature described the use of other types of gaming for library outreach too. Foremost, these games were aimed at providing information literacy instruction to students or introducing them to the library and its resources (Martin & Martin, 2015; Miller, 2014; Spencer, 2015).

Exhibits

Library exhibits were the focus of six ($N=6$) outreach efforts described in the literature and they included a virtual as well as a physical form. Fouracre (2015) noted the rise in library exhibitions and in her interviews with representatives of five libraries in the United Kingdom she concluded the exhibits served as a community, rather than a campus, outreach. On the other hand, in the United States library exhibits aimed to educate and attract students and faculty to the library and included the library walls, the library website, and a library blog (Gluibizzi, 2009; Leousis & Sproull, 2016). The content of these exhibits varied and centered on student and staff publications, new books, media collections, class reading assignments, and promoting diversity and multicultural learning (Delwiche, 2017; Leousis & Sproull, 2016; Maloney, 2012; Wanser, 2014).

Makerspaces

Papers ($N=4$) contained information on makerspace activities, especially pop-up participatory events, and other interactive outreach efforts aimed at faculty as well as students. These activities were designed to teach students and staff about 3D printing and modeling, digital design literacies, and the library's circulating technologies (Purpur, Radniecki, Colegrove, & Klenke, 2016). Rutgers University librarian Megan Lotts documented her various makerspace activities at the institution and beyond that included an edible book contest, holiday card making, polynomiography events, a Lego Playing Station, and hosting LegoMAKE workshops at academic libraries (Lotts 2015, 2016a,b).

Collections

A few papers ($N=3$) pointed to collection development as a form of library outreach to attract targeted users to the library. In addition to promoting their special collections, librarians acquired graphic novels and developed vernacular language videos to enhance foreign students' knowledge of the library's collections and services (Harris & Weller, 2012; Li, McDowell, & Wang, 2016; Slater & Kardos, 2017).

Collaboration

Papers ($N=25$) highlighted the role of collaboration with library staff as well as campus and community groups in facilitating library outreach programs. Collaborations between the library and other campus groups promoted diversity in library collections, enhanced services, multicultural programming, new responsibilities, institutional repositories, innovative

programs, and improved visibility (Anderson, 2014; Booker, 2014; Ghinazzi & Hanson, 2018; Hoseth, 2009; Lotts & Maharjan, 2018; Mathuews & Lewis, 2017; Mendelsohn, 2012; Otto, Meade, Stafford & Wahler, 2016; Passehl-Stoddart, Velte, Henrich, & Gaines, 2018; Vilelle & Barber, 2013; Zitron & Drew, 2011). Library outreach to cultural organizations fostered support for digitalization and preservation efforts for these groups and expanded access to collections and services (Sadongei, Graham, & Helm, 2009; Shell-Weiss, Benefiel, & McKee, 2017; Spang & Yee, 2009; VandeBurgt & Rivera, 2016; Westbrook, Prilop & German, 2012). Collaborations among the university library and other academic libraries, public libraries, and community organizations were aimed at expanding library services to students and area residents and businesses as well as creating digital collections of community information (Burrell, 2009; Etuk & Bridges, 2009; Gibson, Renners, & Stokesberry, 2013; Griffis, 2015; Gritten, 2008; Hoffman, Downey & Sears, 2009; Kostagiolas, Lavranos, Martzoukou & Papadatos, 2015; Mathson, Sabo, & Salisbury, 2009; Simons, 2008).

Management

Information on librarians' management of their outreach efforts was also described in the papers ($N=19$) papers. These papers illustrated the importance of surveys, interviews, assessments and environmental scans in identifying user needs, planning programs, detailing budgets, soliciting volunteers, as well as evaluating and assessing outreach efforts (Dennis, 2012; Del Bosque, Mitola, Skarl, & Heaton, 2017; Farrell & Mastel, 2016; Faulk, 2018; German & LeMire, 2018; Hoffman et al., 2009; Malekani & Benard, 2018; Natal & Atwood, 2018; Samson & Swanson, 2014). Authors also discussed the impact of librarians' management styles on library outreach and they emphasized the need for technical and leadership skills for library outreach. (Forrest, 2010; Toce & Schofield, 2011) Foremost, this research revealed the importance of library outreach to the campus and the communities, the informal management of most outreach efforts, the popularity of library events, the importance of including outreach in library mission statements, the benefits of funding for programs, the role of collaboration, the significance of networking, and the advantages of planning outreach efforts (Carter & Seaman, 2011; Duhon & Jameson, 2013; Huber et al., 2011; Kaspar & Macmillan, 2014; Ramsey, 2016; Seeholzer, 2011). Moreover, the literature highlighted the value partnerships, planning, marketing and assessment for regional library outreach (Clark & Gerke, 2009; Hood & Rogers, 2009).

Social Media

Papers ($N=16$) noted the role of social media tools in library outreach too.

Some best practices for using social media for outreach included obtaining administrative support, identifying students' social media preferences, minimizing posts, developing a social media management plan, creating posting policies, hosting social media posting workshops, linking to social media sites from the library website, monitoring posts, and implementing assessment strategies (Abdullah et al., 2015; Ahenkorah-Marfo & Akussah, 2017; Casey & Worden, 2016; Dickson & Holley, 2010; Glazer, 2009; Harrison, Burress, Velasquez, & Schreiner, 2017; Kelly & Glazer, 2013; Peacemaker, Robinson, & Hurst, 2016; Ure, Atkey, & Miller, 2009; Zhu, 2016). Authors also pointed to the importance of library outreach through Facebook, especially its student groups, as well as Instagram and Twitter's institutional accounts (Hild, 2017; Salomon, 2013; Shulman, Yep, & Tomé, 2015; van Beynen & Swenson, 2016). Lastly, research supported the use of social media to enhance users' awareness and search of special collections (Heyliger, McLoone, & Thomas, 2013; Williamson, Vieira, & Williamson, 2015).

DISCUSSION

A review of the papers ($N=174$) on academic library outreach from 2008 to January 2019 highlighted the popularity of these programs during this period. Early definitions of outreach in the literature included instruction, cooperation, and special programing. The authors found these components to remain true in the papers describing library outreach programs in the previous decade. The authors also identified four themes in these outreach programs during this period including: relevance, collaboration, cultural artifacts, and flexibility.

Relevance

Foremost, librarians created outreach programs that remained relevant to their users. Librarians' outreach programs to targeted groups underscored their attention to relevance. Some of the relevant outreach efforts noted in the literature during these years included the provision of research support in dormitories by resident librarians, the delivery of information literacy instruction in native languages to multicultural groups, the creation of webpages for specific users, and the hosting of library open houses during international week.

Collaboration

Collaboration represented another important component of library outreach programs from 2008 to January 2019. Librarians collaborated with faculty, academic departments and groups, community organizations, local businesses, public libraries and schools, cultural groups, as well as state organizations. These collaborations remained pivotal for library outreach success in securing funding, gathering support, improving librarians' skills, devising programs, serving users, and engaging users.

Cultural Artifacts

The review revealed that librarians centered many of their outreach programs on popular cultural artifacts. These included the use of social media tools, video games, makerspaces, movie films, and graphic novels. The use of these cultural artifacts were aimed at attracting users' attention and interest in outreach programs.

Flexibility

There was evidence of librarians' flexibility in their efforts to provide library outreach. In addition to roaming reference services, librarians offered instruction and research support in popular areas on campus and in the community. They also extended office hours to meet the needs of their users, especially student athletes and adult students. Moreover, outreach programs that encompassed book talks or films were developed to reflect local interests.

Assessment

Authors pointed to the value of assessment, but only a handful of articles detailed efforts to evaluate the success of the outreach program. Comprehensive assessment efforts included qualitative and quantitative data and were utilized to improve future endeavors. Some assessment strategies centered on focus groups and surveys that sought to gauge the impact of the event on students' learning and knowledge of library services. Other outreach assessments examined usage statistics and considered students' comments and other anecdotal information. Overwhelming assessment of outreach events remained positive and led to plans for future programs.

This review documented a variety of library outreach activities adopted by librarians in their efforts to serve campus and community residents. These efforts illustrated new models of library outreach described by

Andrews (2012), Johnson et al. (2003), and Morris (2007). The models were designed to attract a diversity of users to the library. Librarians remained especially creative in their development of outreach activities as well as in their inclusiveness in targeting user groups. The themes of their outreach programs coupled with the user populations they targeted, pointed to the modernization of outreach in academic libraries by early 2019.

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